All Variations — Complete Details — 2026-05-11

Total: 5 variations of the AXEL concept (cascading-cluster slot roguelite).

Quick Reference

ID	Name	V	B	M	Combined	Decision
var-005	AXEL: ZERO	7.0	9.0	5.5	7.2	BUILD NOW
var-002	AXEL: Resonance	8.0	6.5	7.0	7.3	BUILD
var-004	AXEL: Tilt	8.0	5.5	7.0	6.9	BUILD (alt)
var-001	AXEL: Grease	8.0	4.5	7.0	6.5	TEAM REVIEW
var-003	AXEL: Sigil	7.0	4.5	6.0	6.0	TEST / SKIP

VAR-005: AXEL: ZERO

Tier: 1 | **Combined:** 7.2 | **Team:** Solo | **Build:** 1–2 weeks

Source ridden: Moon Princess 100 cascade-cluster mechanics + Balatro/CloverPit zeitgeist + Plinko-style web-virality format **Mechanic:** Cluster pays + cascade + multiplier meter + grid-clear → free spins. Single endless ascending-ante mode (no biomes yet). **Visual:** Emoji symbols on a 5×5 CSS grid. CSS animations for cascade. No commissioned art. **Viral Hook:** Daily seed + auto-generated PNG run summary card + global leaderboard.

Virality Analysis: Cascade clip moment works but emoji visuals cap the ceiling. Daily seed pulls competitive identity loop. Share card is hard-coded K-factor channel.

Buildability Analysis: Web stack (Next.js + Supabase). Reusable cascade/grid logic from any matching-game tutorial. Auto-share-card via canvas API or Vercel OG. Single developer, 1–2 weeks with Claude Code.

Monetization Analysis: Free at launch. Conversion path: "remove ads" tip jar, premium cosmetic skin, $3 Patreon for cosmetic palette. Revenue is secondary; this exists to validate K-factor and seed the audience for the full AXEL.

VAR-002: AXEL: Resonance

Tier: 1 | **Combined:** 7.3 | **Team:** Solo | **Build:** 3–4 weeks (after ZERO)

Source ridden: Same + cosmic/neon aesthetic differentiation **Mechanic:** Core + 4 biome runs (Nebula → Quasar → Void → Supercluster) + biome-specific item pools + sub-casino RTP curves per biome **Visual:** Vector + glow shaders + particle system. No external artist needed — built with libraries like PixiJS or HTML canvas. **Viral Hook:** "Supernova" max-multiplier full-screen moment — explicitly designed to be the 6-second TikTok clip.

Virality Analysis: Highest virality of the set. Visual peak is scientifically tuned for clip-ability. Biome variety creates "look at this absurd Quasar build" shares. Differentiated from CloverPit (horror) and Slots & Daggers (fantasy).

Buildability Analysis: 3–4 weeks solo. Cascade engine, item synergy framework, biome content authoring, run loop, balance tuning. Steam release pipeline.

Monetization Analysis: $9.99–$14.99 premium Steam (matches genre comps). Mobile F2P port in month 3+ with rewarded video for "extra spin" or "skip ante". Cosmetic biome palette DLC.

VAR-004: AXEL: Tilt

Tier: 2 | **Combined:** 6.9 | **Team:** Solo+ | **Build:** 4–6 weeks

Source ridden: Same + anti-casino narrative + heist genre **Mechanic:** Core + "heat" mechanic (cascade adds heat, bust at max) + heist-biome progression **Visual:** Vector + photo-collage, noir palette, neon casino signage **Viral Hook:** Moral narrative "rig the slot that rigs you" — discourse/policy-friendly framing for TikTok.

Virality Analysis: Strongest distinct angle. Doesn't compete on aesthetic with CloverPit; competes on narrative. Strong potential for op-ed coverage / discourse cycles.

Buildability Analysis: Heist UI layer + heat mechanic add complexity over Resonance. 4–6 weeks solo.

Monetization Analysis: Premium $12.99–$14.99 + heist-biome DLC + potential narrative DLC.

VAR-001: AXEL: Grease

Tier: 3 | **Combined:** 6.5 | **Team:** Small | **Build:** 4–6 weeks (with pixel artist)

Source ridden: CloverPit zeitgeist (direct visual lane) + Moon Princess 100 mechanics **Mechanic:** Core + 4 biomes (Boiler Room → Pawnshop → Casino → Vault) **Visual:** Pixel art — needs commissioned art or strong AI pipeline **Viral Hook:** Cascade visual juice within grunge aesthetic. Sits next to CloverPit on Steam wishlist.

Virality Analysis: High but redundant with CloverPit aesthetic — risks being "the discount CloverPit". Mechanical differentiation (cluster cascade vs 1-armed bandit) saves it but visual lane is crowded.

Buildability Analysis: Pixel art bottleneck. 4–6 weeks of dev + parallel artist work. Solo dev would lose 2–4 weeks doing art themselves.

Monetization Analysis: Premium Steam $9.99–14.99.

Why deferred: Without confirmed access to a pixel artist, AXEL: Resonance gets to the same outcome faster with no art bottleneck.

VAR-003: AXEL: Sigil

Tier: 4 | **Combined:** 6.0 | **Team:** Small | **Build:** 5–7 weeks

Source ridden: Fantasy slot-roguelite lane (Slots & Daggers / Runeborn / Slot & Dungeons) **Mechanic:** Core + light boss-combat layer **Visual:** Pixel fantasy **Viral Hook:** Boss-defeat build-share narrative

Virality Analysis: Suffers from being a third entrant in a now-crowded fantasy-slot-roguelite lane. Same V score as ZERO despite higher visual budget — that's a saturation signal.

Buildability Analysis: Combat layer + pixel art + boss design = highest complexity in the set.

Monetization Analysis: Premium Steam but pricing competition vs Slots & Daggers ($9.99) constrains upside.

Recommendation: SKIP unless friend has a strong fantasy IP/angle that meaningfully differentiates.